



The Aletsch Glacier

The longest and largest valley glacier in Europe, some 14 miles (23 km) long, which descends from a particularly scenic area of the Bernese Alps, in Switzerland



The Aletsch Glacier forms from the merger of four smaller glaciers that originate in the southern flanks of the impressive Jungfrau and Monch mountains. The four glaciers converge at a flat ice plateau called Konkordiaplatz at an elevation of 9,022 ft (2,750 m), where the ice is as much as 2,950 ft (900 m) deep.

Movement and retreat

The glacier moves at speeds varying from about 660 ft (200 m) a year in the Konkordiaplatz to 33 ft (10 m) a year near its snout. The pattern of terminal moraines below the snout indicates that it has retreated about 3 miles (5 km) since 1860. Spectacular views down the glacier can be seen from Jungfraujoch, a saddle area in the mountains that is accessible via a steep-grade railroad.

▷ INSIDE THE ALETSCHE

Several ice caves have been carved out by meltwater streams. These are accessible from the glacier's edges and it is possible to enter them and view the brilliant blue interior.

The Aletsch glacier **covers an area of about 31 square miles (80 square km)**

